

Section 4.6:

Using different computers to access the internet

Different **computers** and **devices** can be used to access the **internet**.

In this section we discuss the **advantages** and **disadvantages** of accessing the internet using **desktops**, **laptops**, **tablets** and **smartphones**.

Key Concepts of this section:

- # Understand that different **devices** can be used to access the internet.
- # Be able to **describe** the **advantages** and **disadvantages** of using each device to access the internet.

Accessing the internet using different devices

There are **four** main devices that we can use to access the internet. These are:

- [Desktop PC](#)
- [Laptop](#)
- [Tablets](#)
- [Smartphone](#).

We will discuss the **advantages** and **disadvantages** of using each device for gaining internet access:



Key Words:

Desktop PC , Laptop, Tablet, Smartphone, Internet.

Examples:



The internet can be accessed by several different devices.

1 Desktop PC

Advantages/disadvantages of using desktops to connect to the internet

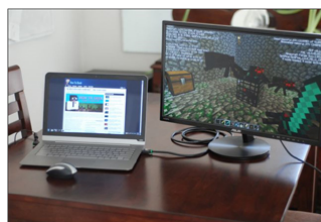
These are summarised in the table below:

Advantages of Desktops	Disadvantages of Desktops
Most websites are designed to be viewed using a desktop. This means web pages will be displayed fully . (Web pages viewed through smartphones often have reduced content due to small screen size)	Desktop PC's are not portable so you can only access the internet from the room where the computer is setup.
Desktops have larger keyboards than all other devices which makes it easier to type keywords into search engines.	
Desktop screens (monitors) are larger than other devices and give a better web page viewing experience. (Everything appears larger which makes navigating web pages easier)	
Desktops usually use wired internet connections which is more stable and reliable than Wi-Fi.	

Examples:



Desktop keyboards are big with large keys. This makes them easy to use.



Desktop screens are larger than other devices and offers superior web page viewing.



Most desktop PC's have a wired internet connection which is more stable than Wi-Fi.

2 Laptop

Advantages/disadvantages of using laptops to connect to the internet

These are summarised in the table below:

Examples:



Advantages of Laptops	Disadvantages of Laptops
More portable than desktops so you can access the internet from more locations.	Less portable than tablets and smartphones.
Larger screen than tablets and smartphones which makes reading web page content easier.	Screens not as large as desktop PC's and web page content may not appear as clearly.
Keyboards on laptops are larger than those of tablets/smartphones and are easier to enter terms into search engines.	Processors (cpu's) in laptops are not quite as powerful as those in desktops. (Web pages may not load as smoothly)
Touchpads on a laptop mean that you can still navigate web pages even if you aren't working on a flat surface . (A desktop's mouse needs a flat surface to operate)	



Laptops are more portable than desktops and can access the internet from more locations.



Laptop touchpads can be used even when there is no flat surface.



Laptops have larger screens than tablets and smartphones.

3 Tablets

Advantages/disadvantages of using tablets to connect to the internet

These are summarised in the table below:

Advantages of Tablets	Disadvantages of Tablets
Smaller and lighter than desktops and laptops. This makes them more portable and much easier to carry. (Internet can be accessed from any location where it is available)	Larger and less portable than smartphones. Use Wi-Fi to connect to the internet which is less reliable than a desktops wired connection.
Larger screen than smartphones which makes reading web page content easier.	Screens are smaller than desktop PC's or laptops and web page content may not display as well. (Modern websites can be designed to change the layout of the page when viewed on smaller screens)
On-screen keyboards are larger than the smartphone version and easier to use.	On-screen keyboards are not as easy to use as the physical keyboards found on desktops and laptops. (Easy to miss-key words and make mistakes)

Examples:



Tablets are smaller than laptops and so are more portable.



Tablets have larger screens than smartphones.



Tablet on-screen keyboards are larger and easier to use than smartphone keyboards.

4 Smartphone

Advantages/disadvantages of using smartphones to connect to the internet

These are summarised in the table below:

Advantages of Smartphones	Disadvantages of Smartphones
The smallest and most portable of all devices that can access the internet. (Internet can be accessed from anywhere where there is a Wi-Fi hotspot or mobile data signal)	Websites displayed on a smartphone are often not the full version of the site. (Web pages viewed on desktops/laptops full sized screen show all content)
People are more likely to have a mobile phone with them wherever they go.	Small screen sizes can make viewing web page content difficult .

Examples:



Smartphones are the most portable of all devices and can access internet anywhere where it is available.

(This means they can have internet access at all times)

Much easier to access the internet whilst **on the move** than laptops or tablets.

Very **small keyboards** can make it difficult to type in **emails** or search engine **keywords**.

Smartphones allow **children** to access the internet from **anywhere**. This can leave them vulnerable to **online predators**.

(Parents may find it difficult to check what their children are up to online)



Websites viewed on smartphones may look different to those viewed on tablets or laptops.



On-screen keyboards on smartphones are small and difficult to use.

Activity!

[Accessing the internet using different devices - Research Sheet](#)

Click the above task and answer the questions about the advantages/disadvantages of accessing the internet using different devices.



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